tives; and *The Garden of the Gods.*

These weren't his first books. When the Second World War forced the Durrells back to England, young Gerald dodged formal schooling to apprentice at pet shops. At Whipsnade Zoo, where he cared for captive wildlife, he despaired that zoos had their priorities wrong. This cemented his goal: to start a zoo that would save endangered animals from extinction at human hands.

With an inheritance from his father's will, he bankrolled expeditions to West Africa and South America. After many trips collecting animals for other zoos, he grew despondent. His wife Jacquie urged him to write. *The Overloaded Ark* (1953), his first book, was successful. Readers adored the animal characters, and he wrote prolifically to raise money and awareness to build his own ark. In 1959, supported by well-heeled trustees, Jersey Zoo opened to the public. The animals he'd been keeping in his sister Margo's garden finally had their own apartments.

READERS ADORED THE ANIMAL CHARACTERS, AND DURRELL WROTE PROLIFICALLY TO RAISE MONEY TO BUILD HIS OWN ARK

In 1977, shortly after Jacquie divorced him, Durrell met Lee McGeorge, an American zoology student 25 years his junior. Today, Lee Durrell helms the Durrell Wildlife Conservation Trust. With the extinct dodo as its mascot, the Trust has transformed zoos into conservation hubs and breeding centres to reintroduce little-known species to rewilded habitats. Durrell was hailed as a modern-day Noah, though in recent years his zoo has faced flak for straying from its founding vision.

Those who grew up on Durrell's books recall his hilarious accounts—fish queuing at barber shops, grumpy Brow-leaf Toads like Lord Mayors in lavatories, and a chimpanzee named Cholmondeley St. John. This volume, lit with Lee's chapter prefaces, reinforces what we know of Durrell with letters, shards from an unpublished autobiography, and photographs. It omits the shadows—financial woes, depression and alcoholism (revealed in Douglas Botting's 2000 biography).

Durrell wrote in the postcolonial afterglow of Empire. Some descriptions may jar modern readers, but he lampooned everyone—including himself. More than anything, he saw humour and charisma in obscure animals—and made humans want to undo their follies. ■

—Bijoy Venugopal



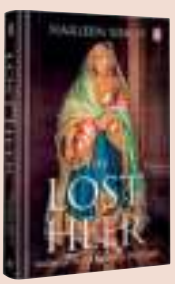
ON FAILING
Edited by Amit Chaudhuri
WESTLAND
₹399; 124 pages

EMBRACING THE FALL

The 'Literary Activism' series—an initiative of the Centre for the Creative and the Critical at Ashoka University and Westland Books—takes on the issue of the creative process's 'failure' and, curiously, its necessity. There are meditative essays by Ranajit Das, Sunetra Gupta, Sumana Roy and Anurag Kashyap, among others, ably curated by series editor Amit Chaudhuri, who also writes an essay.

RECLAIMING THE PAST

Masculinity, this book argues, was a key pillar of Punjabi identity in colonial times. *The Lost Heer* goes beyond male-centric narratives to reclaim the contributions of women through the stories of Aas Kaur, Mai Fatto and Bibi Sahib Kaur in the early colonial period to latter-day figures like Manmohini Zutshi, Raghbir Kaur and others.



THE LOST HEER
By Harleen Singh
PENGUIN VIKING
₹1,299; 544 pages



WANDERERS, ADVENTURERS, MISSIONARIES
By Anuradha Kumar
SPEAKING TIGER
₹599; 384 pages

The Missionary Position

Americans arrived on our shores in the 1700s. This fascinating book unearths a bevy of 'early American' characters, including 'Ice King' Frederic Tudor, who made a fortune shipping ice from Boston to Calcutta; Samuel Evans Stokes, who pioneered apple cultivation in Himachal; and the beloved Alters of Mussoorie.